

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, March 11, 2020, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier
At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor James Contois
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone

Absent:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager

Members of Boy Scout Troop 38 led the Pledge of Allegiance and attended a portion of the Council meeting to help them fulfill some of the requirements of their citizenship badge.

AGENDA CHANGES

None

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Ms. Matteau to accept the minutes of the January 22, 2020, City Council meeting, as amended.

Mr. Morris said on page 7 of the packet, page 6 of the minutes, 3rd paragraph from the bottom “Mary Walter, Finance Director, said making Assessing its own Department does mean adding more money to the budget.” It should say, “making Assessing its own Department does not mean adding more money to the budget.”

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Ms. Matteau to accept the minutes of the February 12, 2020, City Council meeting.

Voice vote: motion carried 7-0, with Mr. Damren abstaining.

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Damren to accept the minutes of the February 26, 2020, City Council meeting.

Voice vote: motion carried 7-0, with Mr. Stone abstaining.

MAYOR'S NOTES

Mayor Lovett thanked the Boy Scout leaders, without whom they couldn't have a troop.

Mayor Lovett's note:

- 17% registered voters came out to vote
- Thank you to voters for coming out and thank you to workers at the polls
- March 19 Council Retreat. Council agreed to hold it at the Claremont Savings Bank Community Center, at 5:30 p.m.
- Ribbon cutting at Goddard Block March 20

Ms. Sweetser said in the past week and a half, Changes thrift store had their Grand Opening and Flow Studios held a tattoo event which raised \$2,200 for Australian Relief.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

Mr. Morris said regarding the coronavirus (COVID-19) that Fire Chief Bryan Burr is the Emergency Management Officer and Steve Coombs is the Health Officer.

- **Coronavirus (COVID-19)** –City staff is working closely with Sullivan County Public Health Network and the New Hampshire Department of Health and Human Services (who is leading the response in New Hampshire) concerning the developing information and public safety initiatives in regard to the Coronavirus. The City is also working closely with the school district and other regional and community organizations to ensure a coordinated effort and response.

Our main objective at this time is to alleviate unnecessary concerns while safeguarding the health of our community. The most important thing each of us can do is to take basic precautions that are commonly used to help minimize the spread of any respiratory illnesses like colds and the flu, which can also help keep an illness like COVID-19 from spreading. These precautions include, but are not limited to:

- Frequent hand washing with soap and water for at least 20 seconds. If soap and water are not available, use an alcohol-based hand sanitizer.
- Avoid touching your eyes, nose and mouth with unwashed hands.
- Avoid close contact with people who are sick.

- Stay home when you are sick.
- Cover your cough or sneeze with your sleeve or a tissue. Throw the tissue in the trash.
- Clean and disinfect frequently touched objects and surfaces.

We will continue to update the Council and public as the situation develops with any guidance or directives that may affect our community. Any time you have a specific question about the virus, you can visit the DHHS website at <https://www.dhhs.nh.gov/dphs/cdcs/2019-ncov.htm> or the CDC website at <https://www.cdc.gov/coronavirus/2019-ncov/index.html>.

City staff has ramped up on cleaning. The public has been asked not to go to facilities if they are sick. The City is staying in close contact with state and school officials.

- **Facebook-** Monday, the City launched its Facebook page, *City of Claremont, NH Government*. There is no plan to engage the public in conversation, but to push out information.
- **Website-** Rebecca Vinduska has been working hard on the new City of Claremont website. We have a tentative launch date of around the beginning of May. There will be a bid page where all RFP's, bid tabulations and awards will be posted. There will be a new alert system where citizens will be able to sign up for email and/or text alerts to be notified when certain pages are updated so they know when new events, agendas, minutes, or other items are added to the website.
- **Airport** – The airport terminal project is scheduled to start this month and is expected to be completed by the end of June. Pine Hill Construction will be the contractor for the project. We are also planning to complete the apron reconstruction project this summer. Along with these two projects, the City is working with Stantec consulting services to plan the runway reconstruction project from the FAA-funded grant we received earlier this year. That project is slated to be completed in 2023.
- **Topstone Mill Testing** – A test well across Mulberry Street from the south side of the Topstone Mill tested high for chlorinated solvents. New Hampshire DES has issued a letter to 116 Mulberry Street (Sweet Fire BBQ) to start an Initial Site Characterization (ISC) to try to learn where and when the chlorinated solvents may have been used at or near this property. As this and future studies/testing are completed, City staff will keep you updated.
- **Farmers Market-** Last year the Farmers Market struggled getting vendors to participate, which, in turn, lowered visitor rates. This year, the City's Parks and Recreation Department is partnering with the Greater Claremont Chamber of Commerce and the West Claremont Center for Music and the Arts to bring you a new and improved Farmers Market. The new market will be held on a monthly basis on the second Saturday of each month (June 13th, July 11th, August 8th and September 12th) from 10 AM to 2 PM in Broad Street Park.

This collaborative effort will provide not only the traditional farmers market vendors, but food and other vendors, as well as a new entertainment act each month from 11:30AM to

1PM. We will also be featuring a hands-on educational component through the West Claremont Center for Music and the Arts. Programming and entertainment are made possible by a grant through Claremont's Union – St. Luke's Church, secured by West Claremont Center for Music and The Arts.

- **Regional Dispatch** – The City has reentered conversations with the Town of Newport concerning the creation of a regional dispatch center. It makes financial sense, with both Newport and Claremont having to replace the equipment in their respective dispatch centers in the near future, to try to work together. On equipment alone, this will save approximately 50% for each community. Through efficiencies, there may be other cost savings. The plan is to build the dispatch center well enough and scalable so that we can add other communities as the need arises. The more communities and agencies that are dispatched through the facility, the more cost savings will be realized by all.
- Public Works found a sewer leak on the Rail Trail and has been able to stop the leak. They are working with NHDES. Under 1,000 gallons escaped the system. Public Works is working to fix the manhole.
- The Census is starting. Everyone is encouraged to fill out the Census survey. It helps with funding sources for the community. All people count.
- March 21 at CSBCC, the Tax Deeded Property Auction will be held. All Certificates of Occupancy have been pulled and a reverter clause has been placed on all those properties.

Victor St. Pierre, Public Works Director, said the spring paving has gone out to bid. The plan is to pave Belding Street; Broad Street from the Rail Trail to the bridge in both directions, mill a 12-foot wide path, do one lane in both directions; hope to have these done between when school gets out and July 1st. Depending on how much paving money gets put in the budget, they are looking at Francis Street, Ridge Avenue, Orchard Road; those need water lines replaced and then they will rebuild those roads. They are also looking at Langseth Avenue and some of Durham and Monarch.

Mr. Koloski asked about the Police Department's crime data that used to be in the packet. Police Chief Mark Chase, said he can speak with the City Manager to see what can be done. When the new website is up, he hopes to put the Police Department log on there.

Mr. Koloski had previously asked about the airport contract going to the Council for approval. Mr. Morris said it has only gone to the Council once in 2013; it looks like it is operational.

Mr. Koloski said regarding Topstone monitoring, that he is a tenant in the property. He said whatever it is, is coming from offsite onto Topstone's site. It is chlorinated solvents. Mr. Morris said it was one well that tested high across the street at Sweet Fire BBQ. DES is continuing to look to see where the chlorinated solvents are coming from.

Mayor Lovett asked where the collapsed manhole was. Mr. Morris said it was in a swampy area on the Rail Trail. The City is working with NHDES to make sure everything is being done properly.

Mr. Contois said regarding the crime data, that he hopes the City Manager is looking at the data and if there are issues, to bring them to the Council's attention.

Mayor Lovett asked if there would be weekly COVID-19 updates. Mr. Morris is working on it. He is also working with the School District and will probably put out joint press releases.

Ms. Matteau asked if COVID-19 test kits are available. Ms. Kier said only the state can test at this time.

Ms. Matteau asked about people sitting at the front desk of the CSBCC and if they are doing proactive screening. Mr. Morris said the City is putting out information that if people are sick, to stay home.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Claremont Planning Board

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Stone to re-appoint David Pacetti to seat 6 of the Claremont Planning Board.

Voice vote: motion carried 7-1 with Ms. Kier voting no.

Upper Valley-Lake Sunapee Regional Planning Commission

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Ms. Matteau to re-appoint Thomas Rock to seat 2 of the Upper Valley-Lake Sunapee Regional Planning Commission.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Mayor Lovett said the terms for the Zoning Board of Adjustment seats held by Abigail Kier and Tracy Pope expire on March 31st. She wants to make sure the Board has enough members in order to hold a hearing on April 6th, that was continued from the March 2nd meeting.

Ms. Kier apologized for forgetting to resubmit her application.

Mayor Lovett said Council will need to waive Council Rules in order to make the appointments at its March 25th meeting.

A motion was made by Ms. Matteau and seconded by Mr. Stone to waive Council Rules in order to allow Council to make board appointments at its March 25, 2020, meeting.

Roll call vote:

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - no

Contois - no

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 6-2.

Mayor Lovett said that Mr. Contois had voiced interest in serving on the Upper Valley Lake Sunapee Regional Planning Commission (UVLSRPC).

Mr. Contois said when he made that statement, there was a vacant seat. He said he has received an email stating that David Pacetti is interested in the seat, so Mr. Contois will not submit an application.

Mayor Lovett asked if any Councilor would like to fill the City Council seat on the Airport Advisory Board. Ms. Sweetser volunteered to sit on the Board.

Ms. Matteau nominated Erica Sweetser to serve on the Airport Advisory Board, City Council Representative seat. Seconded by Ms. Kier.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Mayor Lovett said there was a concern about a person serving on both the Historic District Commission and the Board of Assessors. Mr. Morris said deForest Bearse will reach out to that person.

Mayor Lovett said it has been almost a year that the City Manager has been looking for someone to sit on the Claremont Housing Authority. She asked Councilors if there were any objections to her sitting on that board.

Mr. Morris said it is not a Council seat; it is a resident seat. It is a City Manager appointment. There were no objections.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

None

OLD BUSINESS

Legislative Updates

Mayor Lovett's update:

1. SB599, adopting a health-based measurement for lead in drinking water – On March 3, the Senate Health and Human Services Committee held a public hearing on this bill. Mayor Lovett provided testimony on behalf of the Claremont Lead Action Team. Unless otherwise advised by the Council, the Claremont Lead Action Team will continue following and supporting this bill through the legislative session.
2. HB1539, relocation of children poisoned by lead – The House vote was rescheduled for the week of March 9. Unless otherwise advised by the Council, the City Manager and Mayor will continue following this bill through the legislative session.
3. SB248, raising the legal age for sales and possession of tobacco products – The bill proposes to raise the legal age for sales and possession of tobacco products. The bill was last heard on March 5 by the Senate Commerce and Consumer Affairs Committee. At the time of this writing, the outcome of that hearing was not posted on the NH General Court website. Regardless, the Council, in collaboration with the administration, should discuss its position regarding this bill.

Council agreed to support this bill.

4. HB1402, establishing procedures for municipal host customer-generators of electrical energy – This week, members of the Council received a letter from Governor Sununu requesting support for the bill. On February 19, 2020, the House voted 188-148 to refer this for interim study. The Council, in collaboration with the administration, should discuss its position on this.

Mayor Lovett said this has been sent for interim study. This could benefit the City. She would like to hear from the Administration. After Councilors review, they should send their thoughts to Ms. Russell.

5. SB458, prohibiting municipalities from restricting short term rentals - Cordell Johnston, attorney at NHMA, requested that we contact our senator and ask her to oppose this bill as it removes local authority. Please refer to the NHMA bulletin sent on February 28 for details on why municipalities should oppose this bill. It is expected that it will be voted on by the Senate Election Law and Municipal Affairs Committee on Wednesday, March 11, and then by the full Senate the following week. Therefore, any thoughts on this should be forwarded, via Doree, as soon as possible.

6. SB482, allowing tiny houses in all residential districts – Mr. Johnston also requested that we contact our senator and ask her to oppose this bill as it also removes local authority. Please refer to the NHMA bulletin sent on February 28 for details on why municipalities should oppose this bill. It is expected that it will be voted on by the Senate Election Law and Municipal Affairs Committee on Wednesday, March 11, and then by the full Senate the following week. Therefore, any thoughts on this should be forwarded, via Doree, as soon as possible.

After discussion, the majority of the Council supported NHMA's opposition to SB458 and SB482.

HB1443, switch appointment of the Police Commissioners from the City Manager to the Council, she noted that it "ought to pass," but the minority requested an amendment; they felt an amendment was needed to fix the political litmus test.

NEW BUSINESS

City Fee Schedule – Public Hearing

Mr. Morris said a \$25 fee for use of electricity in Broad Street Park was added to Permit - Hawkers & Peddlers and Itinerant Vendors.

Monitoring of Private Fire Alarm Systems Inside City Limits/Wired System was increased from \$665.00 per box/per year, to \$740.00. There are fewer people on the system and this change is to cover the cost of the system.

Planning & Development's change to all Legal Notices from \$35.00 to \$50.00 is due to increases in advertising costs.

Mayor Lovett said last year the Fee Schedule went to the Finance Committee. If Councilors agree with the changes they can vote, or they can vote to send this to the Finance Committee.

Mayor Lovett asked about Airport fees. Mr. Koloski said the FBO, Fixed Base Operator, collects the fees, he thinks they should be reflected in the Fee Schedule.

Mr. Morris said there are long-term hangar leases and those fees come to the City. The FBOs have some hangar fees that go to the FBOs and they pay the City a lease payment of \$150 a month for the main terminal building.

Fire Chief Bryan Burr talked about the hangar lease agreements and fees. The City has six box hangars with five-year leases on each of them. Those leases are set to expire in August 2021. CNH Aviation LLC, FBO, holds the lease on the terminal building and they pay \$150/month, or \$1,800/year. Two hangars generate funds to them. The fees they collect are their income. The

six box hangars generate \$2,400/year and those funds go into the Airport Reserve Fund. Those have lease agreements. He said if those fees are included in the Fee Schedule and then in August 2021 a new fee is negotiated, it will cause a conflict.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Koloski to re-adopt the City Fee Schedule.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Ordinance 573 Planning Board Creation – First Reading

The purpose of this proposed change is to amend Section 2-116 of the Claremont City Code to specify the composition of the city planning board and provide for the appointment of planning board members and alternates. This information has previously been included only in city planning board regulations; however, the planning board is not empowered to determine the composition of or to appoint planning board members. State law reserves the composition and appointment of planning board members in cities with a city manager form of government to the City Council.

Enactment of this Ordinance will include the composition and appointment of city planning board members in the City Code and changes the composition and selection method for city planning board members and alternates. The City Administration has requested this change.

Mayor Lovett said this should reflect that the Council and City Administration requested the change.

Mr. Damren read the ordinance into the record.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Matteau to adopt Ordinance 573 Planning Board Creation on first reading.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Discuss Claremont Housing Authority Project Based Vouchers for Goddard Block

Mr. Morris said he has been approached by the Claremont Housing Authority asking him to sign a document stating that they have a five-year plan. This document is a part of their application process for Section 8 Project Based Vouchers, that will be assigned to the Goddard Block. He introduced Michelle Aiken, Claremont Housing Authority (CHA), and Marcia Franklin, Alliance Asset Management. He wanted to have this discussion with the Council before he signs the document allowing the CHA to move forward. The CHA is not the only place that these vouchers can come from. This is not an effort to stop Project Based Vouchers (PBH) from going in the Goddard Block, this is a discussion of whether we want to do it through the CHA. This is a great time to discuss how the structure of the Goddard Block is set up (i.e. mixed income housing and how it would work).

Marcia Franklin, Chief Operating Office, Alliance Asset Management (AAM), said that AAM is the company overseeing the Goddard Block. The Goddard has 36 units, 8 units are designated to 50% of the average median income for Sullivan County, 19 units are under 60%, and 9 units are market rate. The PBVs from CHA will be used for units that are currently subsidized. Part of the funding for building this facility requires acceptance of these vouchers.

Michelle Aiken said the main reason CHA wants to do this, is because they are allowed to have 140 vouchers from HUD. For the past 5 years, they have been at 130 vouchers or below. PBVs are not part of their portfolio. To be a part, they need a form signed by the City Manager. HUD allows them to Project Base up to 20% of her vouchers. They'll start with 10. The Goddard would get vacancy payments those apartments are unoccupied. CHA has a waiting list of about 140 people. The management company will help to recruit people. She'll pass the waiting list onto AAM. A lot of time, people don't follow through with the paperwork. This will help push the vouchers and get people into apartments.

Ms. Franklin explained the vouchers will be used for the 50% and 60% units.

Ms. Franklin said there will be a Resident Service Coordinator that will be onsite once a week. They will do activities with residents. Within 60 days, they will survey the residents to find out what they need (i.e. transportation). The property manager will come every 2 weeks. There is 24-hour emergency on call for issues with the building. She is reachable 24/7. 60% AMI for 4 people is \$48,960, and 50% is \$40,800. She said there will be a ribbon cutting on Friday. After the tenant lives there for one year, then CHA can offer them a mobile voucher, if available. For most applications, typically, both adults are working and they have young families.

Felony convictions will disqualify an applicant.

Applicants with evictions are also disqualified.

Ms. Kier is in favor of this. The more manpower working on this the better. Section 8 doesn't mean bad people.

Ms. Matteau said there is a long waiting list and this is going to take 10 vouchers out of the pool.

Mr. Stone is not in favor of the City Manager signing the document.

Ms. Sweetser said there was a public outcry about low income housing in downtown. In 2017 at the Zoning Board of Adjustment, Kevin LaCasse said it would be workforce housing, no Section 8 with the building. The City is working very hard to revitalize the downtown, and pushing Section 8 vouchers will contradict the revitalization.

Ms. Franklin said the building is workforce housing. They are affordable units. Legally, they have to accept voucher holders.

To wrap it up, Mayor Lovett said that if Mr. Morris signs the paper allocating the PBV for 10 units, they would be subsidized by HUD. Ms. Franklin said it will be for 10 years. Mayor Lovett said if Mr. Morris doesn't sign the paper, then no apartment is locked in. Ms. Franklin agreed.

Mayor Lovett asked for consensus:

Ms. Kier - yes

Ms. Sweetser - no

Mr. Damren - yes

Ms. Matteau – no (there is still a need in Claremont for these vouchers)

Mr. Koloski – no

Mr. Contois – yes

Mr. Stone – no

Mayor Lovett – concerned that if you lock in PBVs, and they still work with CHA, then there is a risk of having more than 10

Ms. Franklin clarified that she can accept a voucher, not just from CHA, but also from NH Housing and they have a 10-year waiting list. If they use the CHA list, these are local people.

Mayor Lovett – based on that, she is in support

Policy Committee Alternate Member

Mr. Koloski said he thought it made sense to have an alternate member of the Policy Committee.

After discussion Councilors agreed that an alternate member was not needed.

Council Expenditures Eligible for Reimbursement

There was a discussion about conferences, mileage for the conferences, business cards, a need to improve the audio in Council Chambers, etc. After the discussion, there was consensus that if the expense is over \$250, that request needs to come to the Council for approval. All agreed to have the expenses reported on the Finance Department's monthly report to the Council.

Discussion re: Municipal Ordinances Pertaining to Drug Related Activity

Mayor Lovett said it was brought to her attention by Mr. Koloski that a business in the area is selling devices that are marketed to be used for tobacco, but could be used for other drug activity. Her preliminary research showed that if a business can say a product is being used for a legal activity, then they can sell it (even though it can be used for illegal activity). She spoke to NHMA and was told that it could be addressed through the Zoning Board of Adjustment (i.e. address it with age restriction).

Police Chief Mark Chase said that it doesn't turn into drug paraphernalia until its used for drugs. He said that if there were a City ordinance preventing sale of those products, he doesn't know how much time the Claremont Police Department could put toward this.

There was a discussion, including that this was being sold in a school zone; it's a personal choice not to go to those stores; it's not drug paraphernalia until it is used as such; Mr. Contois thinks the Council should take a position stating that it is not okay in a school zone.

Ms. Matteau would like the Council to make a formal statement that these things are not wanted in this community. Mayor Lovett suggested reviewing state/federal law.

Water and Wastewater Rates Update

Public Works Director Victor St. Pierre said this is the 5th year of a 5-year plan for water rates. The City is working to get the water and sewer rates so they are sustainable and the City can continue to improve infrastructure. The City has moved away from using the water from the Sugar River (unless needed), to using the water from the City's reservoirs. The City has made some repairs to the reservoirs and those fixes should be good for about 50 years. Money will need to be spent on distribution in the near future. The City is hoping to apply for an EPA lead grant to replace all lead lines in City; it's an 80% grant. The goal in the next two years is to be net zero (for energy) in the water plant. NHDES is doing an energy audit for us at no cost. The distribution side is getting more water through the intake pipe and Public Works is fixing leaks; last year, they found 100,000 gallons a day. He talked about the Asset Management Plan, which is in its third year. The City has at least 60 streets that have water pipes that are 70 years old, or older, which have 50-year life spans. The wastewater system is oversized; it can process 3.89 million gallons/day, but is only running about 1.5 million gallons/day. The City wants to keep that capacity for economic development. The system is 35 years old and will need upgrades. The City has received a grant to replace blowers which will cut electricity usage by a third. As part of the permit to operate, we have to follow EPA phosphorus & nitrogen limits. The next permit is due in 18 months, and he is not sure what the limits will be. He said if they tighten those much more, the City will have to spend \$1.7 million on an upgrade to the Wastewater Treatment Plant (WWTP). We are seeing some savings through energy savings with the solar array (produces about 20% of the electricity used); the new blowers will reduce that to about 50% of the electricity that was being used. The WWTP is the largest user of electricity in the City. Leaks are being fixed, so not as much material is being treated.

The City has one of the few composting facilities in the state and it meets the state's stringent parameters for PFAS. There are no PFAS in our water system. Regarding disposal of WWTP solids, last year that cost went wild. A lot of landfills stopped taking the sludge; this plant produces 4,000 tons of sludge a year. We're not able to get as much wood ash to compost it with, so now we are mixing it with sawdust, and some wood ash, and it is being spread on some farmers' fields. We were having to truck it to Canada for disposal at \$90/ton, which we don't have to do now.

Paul Cioffi, Water & Sewer Bookkeeper, showed a Water and Sewer Rate Update City of Claremont, NH, PowerPoint.

- ❖ What Goals Should Rates Achieve
 - Ensure a safe water supply
 - Cover all costs (full-cost recovery)

- In 4th year of 5-year rate plan. July 1st increase will kick in
- Be affordable
- Maintain adequate cash reserves
- Don't drive businesses away
- ❖ Full-Cost Recovery
 - Revenues that cover:
 - Operating expenses (cash outlays)
 - Debt payments (cash outlays)
 - Depreciation (non-cash outlays)
- ❖ Rates That are Affordable - % of Median Household Income is Used as a Guide
 - FY 2020 Claremont's percentage 1.9%
 - Average for state of NH 2.1%
 - Benchmark range cost for W&S 2%-3%
- ❖ Maintain Adequate Cash Reserves – In 2018 Approved 3 Reserves Each for Water & Sewer
 - Offset fluctuations in revenue
 - Cover emergency repairs
 - Fund emergency capital needs
- ❖ Don't Drive Businesses Away
 - Rate structure has 5 tiers
 - Rates not favorable to small businesses
- ❖ Claremont Current Rate Structure
 - Reason this rate structure put in place few years ago was because we had large water users. Wheelabrator was 10% of our water usage.
- ❖ Claremont Water Customers Usage and Associated Charges for FY2018
- ❖ FY2020 Monthly Water & Sewer Bill Comparison (Claremont, Newport, Lebanon, Keene, and Hanover)
 - Average for 1-person household – Claremont lowest
 - Average residential use – Claremont about average
 - Commercial/restaurant, laundromat – Claremont water well above other communities; sewer lower; overall on the high end
- ❖ Revenue Requirements vs Revenue – Water
 - 2020 covered all cash outlays and almost all depreciation
 - Does not include capital
 - In 2021, will cover all outlays plus depreciation, plus \$200,000
- ❖ Revenue vs Revenue Requirements – Sewer
 - Rates stayed same
 - Sewer rates just barely covering existing cash outlays and debt
 - Not covering depreciation or capital
 - Cash balance coming down
- ❖ Cash Reserves
 - Water target reserve @ 6/30/19 \$1,653,626
 - Water target proposed reserve @ 6/30/19 \$,358,084
 - Sewer target reserve @ 6/30/19 \$4,448,277
 - Sewer target proposed reserve @ 6/30/19 \$3,986,254

- System replacement calls to put away 5% on water side and 10% on sewer until you get to depreciation level, \$8 million water, \$16 million sewer. Will be difficult to get to those levels
- By charging rates that will replace the system. Doing on water side, not sewer
- May be worthwhile to look @ system replacement reserve.

Mr. Cioffi said a review of the rate structure would be beneficial. He said another increase is scheduled to go into effect July 1st.

Council agreed to send this to the Finance Committee. Staff will be included in the discussions.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Mr. Damren said the Finance Committee has been working on the Purchasing Policy, paying attention to the dollar amounts, as the current one was set in place in 2003 and a lot has changed. Staff has recommended to move some amounts up. Need to look at the disposal of City assets. The Finance Committee has requested the Council move this policy, in its entirety, to the Policy Committee for finalization and fine tuning.

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Koloski to move the Purchasing Policy (work that has been done by the Finance Committee) to the Policy Committee.

Voice vote: motion carried 7-1 with Mr. Contois voting no.

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Mr. Stone to move the presentation of the water and sewer rate update to the Finance Committee for further deliberation.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Mr. Koloski asked about graffiti, the Amtrak sign has been vandalized.

Mr. Koloski said in the past, there has been a Boards and Commissions dinner honoring all the board, commission and committee members and suggested it was time to do it again.

Mr. Koloski said all Councilors received an email about zoning; he asked if it were going to be a future agenda item. Mr. Morris said there was no plan for it to be a future agenda item. Mr. Contois had asked for the information, and Mr. Morris wanted to see the variances himself, so he directed the Planning and Development Department to put that information together. Mayor Lovett said if the City is giving out a lot of variances, then the policy should be reviewed. Ms. Kier said it has been brought up multiple times that the signage policy is out of date. Mayor Lovett said that can be put on an agenda, and Ms. Kier and anyone else sitting on the ZBA can talk about it.

Ms. Matteau asked about the land use boards being trained by a land use attorney.

Ms. Kier said there was training when the City had an in-house attorney. More could be done.

Mr. Koloski said citizens are concerned about a street light that stays on at the Bank of NH.

Mr. Koloski said the intersection of North & Main Streets, by Tractor Supply, is extremely dark.

Mr. Koloski talked about the old crosswalk markings in front of City Hall which are confusing. Mr. St. Pierre said Public Works had painted them black, but the paint wore, so they will have to grind off the white marks.

Ms. Sweetser referenced an email received from a citizen and asked what the process is for addressing when a board member has committed a crime; can the Council remove them. Ms. Matteau would like the board member to be approached and asked to voluntarily step down. Mr. Koloski agreed and suggested the City Manager ask him. Mayor Lovett said the NH Library Trustees Association has a trustees manual that has a section on code of ethics. Knowing it is part of the manual, she hopes the Fiske Free Library Board of Trustees will have that discussion. Mr. Morris said he has been in contact with Library Director regarding this.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 10:14 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Matteau to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council